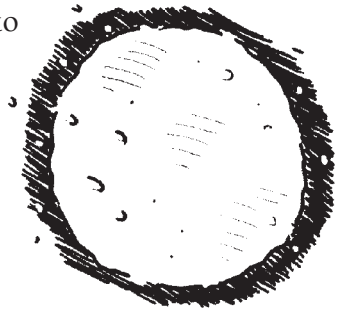
Read Words in Context

READ!

The Fourth Rock From the Sun



Have you ever considered traveling to the **barren** planet Mars at some point in the future? Right now, there's nothing on Mars—no air, food, or water! Nothing can grow there. It is like a desert with swirling dust storms. The ground is **coarse**, covered with rocks and red dirt. Some rocks are as small as a **kernel** of corn while others are large like boulders.

What will your trip be like? If your spaceship stays on **course**, it will take you six months to get to Mars. To keep you from being bored on the long trip, you can read, write, and play music. You can strum a **chord** on your guitar and make up a song about the "fourth rock from the sun."

You will need some **aid** if you decide to travel to Mars. You will need help dealing with the bitter cold and wild storms. Your **aide** could be a robot, because a machine would not be hurt by the frigid cold and lack of air.

You will also need supplies. Be sure to bring along a lot of **cord** to tie to rocks to help you climb and explore the canals on Mars. Hold onto the rope as you climb down into these dried river beds.

You might find some unusual things on Mars. Of course, these wouldn't be Martians! Rather, they would be the Viking and Pathfinder probes that the United States landed on Mars.

Several human missions to Mars are planned for the future. Usually, a **colonel** or other military person flies these dangerous missions. When they return from their dangerous missions, these brave and daring people are treated like a **baron**, or other royal person.

So why would you take a trip to Mars? You want to have the fun of being one of the first people to ever set foot on the "fourth rock from the sun!"

Vocabulary Words

aid/aide
baron/barren
chord/cord
coarse/course
colonel/kernel

Word Learning Tip!

Homophones are words that sound alike but are spelled differently and have different meanings. Usually, they have different word origins. This means that they came into English from words in other languages that were very different.

Vocabulary Building Strategy

Knowing something about the language from which an unfamiliar word comes can be a clue to its meaning. Some of the words in this vocabulary lesson come from Old English, an early form of our language. Others come from French, Italian, Greek, and Latin. Over time, their spelling and pronunciation changed a bit. When you read a word from another language, connect what you know about its history to context clues to determine its meaning.

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Connect Words and Meanings

aid/aide **baron/barren** **chord/cord** **coarse/course** **colonel/kernel**

Directions Read each sentence below. Circle the best definition for each boldface word.

1. The noun **colonel** comes from the Old French word *coronel*. The French adapted an Italian word that meant "commander of a column of soldiers."
   Definition: small seed statue officer in the U.S. Military
2. The noun **chord** comes from a shortened form of the word "accord," which means "agreement." In music, a chord creates a pleasant sound because the notes are in harmony or agreement.
   Definition: singing three or more tones string instruments
3. The noun **kernel** comes from an Old English word that meant "base of corn or grain," or "formed from corn seed." We also use the word to refer to the most important part of something.
   Definition: plant fruit grain or seed
4. The noun **cord** comes from an ancient Greek word for "catgut." Perhaps that's because early cord was made from animal gut.
   Definition: saxophone string wire
5. The adjective **barren** comes from Middle English and was used to describe soil that wouldn't grow healthy plants. We use the word the same way today.
   Definition: not fertile rich fertile
6. The noun **course** comes from a Latin word for "run." Today, people often run on a course but the word also refers to a series of lessons that help you to learn a subject.
   Definition: rough nobleman path
7. The noun **aide** comes from a Latin word for "help." It is a shortened form of the word *aide-de-camp*, which is a word from French that means "military officer acting as a secretary or helper."
   Definition: assistant friend teacher
8. The noun **baron** comes from an old French word for "freeman." In Middle English, the word referred to a lord. A baron ranks below an earl.
   Definition: great leader nobleman wealthy
9. The adjective **coarse** comes from a Middle English word that meant "rough, rude." Both people and things can be coarse.
   Definition: tough racetrack not smooth
10. The verb **aid** comes from a Latin word that means "help."
    Definition: follow sing assist

Understand Multiple Meanings Some homophones have more than one meaning. Use your dictionary to find another meaning for *aid, barren, chord, coarse, cord, course*.

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Use Words in Context

aid/aide **baron/barren** **chord/cord** **coarse/course** **colonel/kernel**

Directions Answer each question below on the line. Use the boldface word in your response.

1. Don't write a news story without a **kernel** of truth. Why not?

2. Don't talk back to a **colonel** if you are a soldier. Why not?

3. Don't try to become a **baron** in the United States. Why not?

4. Don't try to grow plants on **barren** land. Why not?

5. Don't play a **chord** of music on the piano too loudly while others are trying to sleep. Why not?

6. Don't use a thin **cord** to jump into a canal on Mars. Why not?

7. Don't wear a garment under your spacesuit made of scratchy, **coarse** fabric. Why not?

8. Don't look for a race **course** on Mars. Why not?

9. Don't **aid** someone if you don't know how to help. Why not?

10. Don't be rude to your **aide**. Why not?

Understand More Homophones About People *Colonel* and *baron* are homophones that refer to people. One word in each of the following pairs of new homophones also refers to a person or persons: *principal/principle, heir/hair, residents/residence*. Find the histories and meanings for one of these homophone pairs. Write about it in your word journal. Then write a sentence using each word that shows that you understand its meaning.

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Put Words Into Action

aid/aide baron/barren chord/cord coarse/course colonel/kernel

Directions Imagine that you are a scientist being interviewed for a newspaper article about traveling to Mars. You've been asked the following questions. Be imaginative in answering each one. Use the vocabulary word in parentheses ( ) in your answer.

1. What route should we take to get to Mars? (course)

2. Who should command our mission to Mars? (colonel)

3. What supplies should we bring? (cord)

4. How can we entertain ourselves on the six-month flight? (chord)

5. How would you describe the landscape on Mars? (barren)

6. What is the soil like? (coarse)

7. Can we plant crops? (kernel)

8. What help can you give us with planning our trip? (aid)

9. Do you think we need a helper on board, too? (aide)

10. Who would be good for this job? (baron)

Write a Martian Weather Report Write a weather report for an average day on Mars. Remember that the temperature on Mars often goes from -90°F in the morning to 0° at noon and -280°F at night! There's no water, but there are fierce dust storms. Use at least five vocabulary words in your weather report.

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Review and Extend

aid/aide baron/barren chord/cord coarse/course colonel/kernel

Bonus Words Below are two more pairs of homophones.

Words	History	Meaning
right	from an Old English word	correct
write	from a Greek word for "drawing"	to form letters; to compose
weather	from an Old English word	climate
whether	from a Middle English word	if

Directions The story below tells about the exploration of Mars. Choose the correct homophone to complete each sentence. Use the context clue in boldface to help you determine which homophone to use.

1. People wanted to learn more about the **climate** on Mars. They wanted to learn about the _____.
2. They were curious to see **if** Mars was safe for people. They sent probes to find out _____ humans could live on Mars.
3. Scientists **describe** the soil, rock, and air samples the probes brought back. The scientists _____ about this data.
4. The scientists use the **correct** way to look at the samples. Using the _____ way makes sure that the samples are not harmed.
5. The early pictures from Mariner 4 in 1965 were **rough**. They were _____ and grainy.
6. Today's clearer pictures **help** us learn a lot about Mars. They _____ our understanding of the planet.
7. We see that it is **empty** except for dry riverbeds. It is a _____ planet, with no trees, rivers, or oceans.
8. What **path** will future explorations take? The _____ is clear: soon, we plan to land people on Mars!

Put on a Skit Imagine that you have landed on Mars. Working with some classmates, put on a skit to describe the event. As you write your script, be sure to include at least five new pairs of homophones that you will teach to the class.

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Check Your Mastery

aid/aide **baron/barren** **chord/cord** **coarse/course** **colonel/kernel**

Directions Read each item below. Then write the vocabulary word that best completes each sentence. Use each vocabulary word only once.

1. Jami played a _____ (*cord, kernel, chord*) on her guitar by strumming the strings with her fingers.

2. Nothing would grow in the _____ (*baron, barren, course*) soil, not even weeds.

3. Because he had been training for weeks, Luke easily ran the race _____ (*course, coarse, aid*).

4. The teacher's _____ (*chord, aide, aid*) stayed in the classroom the entire day, helping the students with their assignments.

5. Rick likes to eat one _____ (*kernel, colonel, chord*) at a time from his corn on the cob.

6. The _____ (*coarse, baron, course*) fabric was stiff and scratchy.

7. The _____ (*kernel, aid, colonel*) stood at attention, his hand at his uniform hat, while the flag was raised.

8. Thank you for the _____ (*aid, aide, course*); we really needed your help.

9. Please tie the bundle of newspaper with _____ (*kernel, chord, cord*) so it is easy to lift.

10. The _____ (*baron, kernel, barren*) sometimes did not use his nobleman's title.

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